To my detriment, I spent too many innings walking out onto the pitch trying to execute a conservative game plan. I just should have said, 'To hell with what the coach says; I am just going to go out there and play my natural game.' I always appreciated Duncan Fletcher for letting me be myself on the field. Whenever he was involved with a team I played for, his advice to me would be: 'If you want to hit the first ball of the game over extra cover, well, go for it.'

Not the Proteas, though. Once or twice I tried to suggest that we do things a bit differently, but my input would just get pushed aside. I wouldn't say laughed off, but they weren't really interested. Everything is so structured, you know, nothing instinctive or spontaneous is allowed.

The point I'm trying to make is that I really should've been more carefree in my cricket back then, because these days, despite wanting to play an all-out aggressive innings, I find myself batting really responsibly. I find there's a bit of inner conflict in my game at the moment, which is the result of my stay at Harmony Clinic. It's made me regret that I didn't go for it more when I was younger, when I would have revelled in the freedom.

What I'm going through now is necessary for my development as a cricketer and as a person, but it's not easy. My time at Harmony Clinic was a life-changing experience. Ever since, I've been thinking very deeply about my life, which obviously includes my cricket. This notion of 'responsibility' has been bouncing around my head ever since I left the clinic, and the role I feel I need to play in all my teams as a senior player has subdued my out-and-out aggressiveness. The more I think about stuff, the more the word 'responsibility' comes up … and they say that you take your personality onto the field with you.

A reporter recently asked me what was happening with my batting. Why wasn't I going after the ball quite like I used to – even in 20/20 cricket? I couldn't answer the guy, because I know that no matter whether it is the Proteas, the Deccan Chargers or the Cobras, I *have* to bat through most of the overs. I've sort of got into that way of thinking. At the Chargers, if Adam Gilchrist, Andrew Symonds, Rohit Sharma or I didn't fire, it put too much pressure on the rest of the guys, which they can't handle because a lot of them are still so young. The same principle applies at the Cobras.

The situation has created a real conflict inside me. I really don't want to lose my aggressiveness – especially in the 20/20 game – but at the same time I have to consider what's best for the team. Man, since I've come out